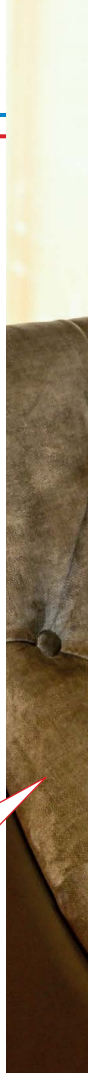
At a time when India-US relations were hampered by a trust deficit, two of Washington's most influential interlocutors, *US Secretary of State and National Security Advisor* MARCO RUBIO, who was in Mumbai on his second visit to India in less than five months, and *US Ambassador to India* SERGIO GOR, sat down with INDIA TODAY *Group Editorial Director* Raj Chengappa for a candid discussion on the challenges and imperatives shaping the relationship. From the elusive bilateral trade deal and India's energy security needs to Russian oil purchases, defence and technology cooperation, the H-1B visa crackdown and concerns over Washington's growing proximity to Pakistan, the two shared their insights into America's strategic priorities and the leadership style of their boss, US president Donald Trump. Excerpts:



Q. If you were to rate the India-US relationship on a scale of one to 10, with 10 being a perfect partnership, what score would you give it, and why?

Marco Rubio: I wouldn't put a number, I would say it's a very important relationship. Obviously, it's two big, important countries. We've worked together for a very long time. We have a lot of common interests, and we have a history of working together. And I think India's progressing so fast on so many areas that are important to the national security and national interest of the United States. It's a logical partnership. So, I don't know about one to 10. I would say it is as strong as it's ever been, and I think in five years, we'll look back and say it's one of the strongest relationships in the world.

Q. What are the two or three things you plan to focus on right now?

Rubio: Well, we'd like to get this trade agreement done because I think that provides stability and certainty for everyone. And then beyond that, I think there are so many areas we can work on, on energy and certainly on technology, artificial intelligence and things of this nature, telecommunications. There's so much we can work on—biomedical, pharmaceuticals—you name it. I could go on for an hour.

Sergio Gor: I will add that pick any sector, and today, the United States and India are working on it closer, at a higher level, and are more engaged, whether that's pharma, or military exercises. You know, India has more military exercises with the United States than anyone else. So, any sector—IT, of course, sales, our bilateral trade—we're working at it at a much higher level than ever before.

Q. On trade, President Donald Trump has said that India and the US are close to signing an agreement that would be different from others. Is Washington willing to offer India the competitive tariff advantage it is seeking under this interim trade deal?

Rubio: Well, I'm not going to get into the specifics of any agreement until they're done, because there are still a number of items being negotiated, although very few. So, we're very close, and I can't foresee anything that will keep us from reaching an agreement, but there's still some items being discussed. So, I'd prefer not to go into the details of it until it's all fully worked out. Suffice to say that once this deal is done, it has to be one that's beneficial to both countries, and that's what I anticipate it will be.

> **"We're close to reaching a deal, one beneficial to both countries. The point of an agreement is to have certainty so that people can invest, people know the rules governing trade and commerce"**

> **"It's in India's interests to diversify its energy portfolio. It's not so much about buying less Russian oil but buying more crude from the US, Venezuela or others from the western hemisphere"**
> **— RUBIO**

Q. India expects continuity rather than unpredictability in trade relations. Yet there is a Super 301 provision hanging over our heads. Can we expect continuity and not a continuous revision of tariffs?

Rubio: Well, the point of an agreement is to be able to have certainty so that people know they can invest, people know what the rules governing trade and commerce between the two countries are going to be. That's the very purpose of having a deal. And that's what we're working towards, and I feel very optimistic that we're going to get to a very good place very soon.



Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**